POSITIONING IN THE ACADEMIC COMMUNITY

Part 1

Persuasion, Interaction and the Construction of Knowledge: Representing Self and Others in Research Writing

Introduction

The view that academic writing is persuasive dates back at least as far as Aristotle and is widely accepted by academics themselves. The ways that this persuasion is achieved, however, is more contentious and raises a number of important issues, not least those concerning the relationship between reality and accounts of it, the efficacy of logical induction, and the role of social communities in constructing knowledge. In the past decade or so analyses of academic corpora have brought new empirical insights to these enduring debates in epistemology and the sociology of science, challenging the role of induction or falsification and emphasising the importance of rhetorical practices in academic persuasion.

In this paper I bring my own small contribution to the discussion. In particular, I want to look at what rhetorical interactions tell us about the ways persuasion is accomplished in academic contexts and how knowledge is socially constructed. I am interested in what this tells us about writers' ideas of appropriate writer-reader relationships and how this, in turn, contributes to knowledge-making in the disciplines.

The Nature of Academic Persuasion

I want to begin with a few words about academic persuasion. Academic discourse is a privileged form of argument in the modern world, offering a model of rationality and detached reasoning. It is seen to depend on the demonstration of absolute truth, empirical evidence or flawless logic, representing what Lemke (1995, p. 178) refers to as the discourse of “Truth.” It provides an objective description of what the natural and human world is actually like and this, in turn, serves to distinguish it from the socially contingent. We see it as a guarantee of reliable knowledge; a form of persuasion free of the cynicism with which we view the partisan rhetoric of politics and commerce.

This view is most strongly represented by the natural sciences. The label 'scientific' confers reliability on a method and prestige on its users; it implies all that is most objective and empirically verifiable about academic knowledge. As a result, it has been imitated by other areas of human inquiry which are often considered softer and more rhetorical in their forms of argument. Underlying this realist model is the idea that knowledge is built on experiment, induction, replication, and falsifiability. Scientific papers are seen as persuasive because they communicate truths which emerge from our direct access to the external world. The text is merely the channel through which scientists report observable facts. A reason, no doubt, for the marginalization of academic literacies at universities, where writing is typically regarded as just reporting more important things that go on elsewhere.

But scientific methods provide less reliable bases for proof than commonly supposed. Although we rely on induction in our everyday lives, believing that the bus we take to work will pass by at 8am tomorrow if it has passed at 8am every day for the past week, it has been criticized by philosophers of science. They argue that induction offers probabilities rather than proof, and by moving from observations of instances to general statements about unobserved cases, scientists introduce uncertainty. Nor is the widely accepted alternative, Popper's process of 'falsification', which puts theories through experimental testing and replaces those that are defective with more verifiable ones, any more reliable. It is simply not possible to conclusively falsify a hypothesis because the

observations that form the basis for the falsification must be expressed in the language of some theory, and so will only be as reliable as that theory.

The problem for scientific knowledge, then, is that interpretation always depends on the assumptions scientists bring to the problem (e.g. Kuhn, 1970). That is, all reporting occurs within a pragmatic context and in relation to a theory which fits observations and data into meaningful patterns, so there is no secure observational base upon which any theories can be tested. As the Nobel physicist Stephen Hawking (1993, p. 44) notes: "a theory may describe a range of observations, but beyond that it makes no sense to ask if it corresponds to reality, because we do not know what reality is independent of a theory."

In other words, there is always going to be at least one interpretation for research data, and the fact that we can have these competing explanations shifts attention away from the lab or the library to the ways that academics argue their claims. We have to look for proof in textual practices for producing agreement.

Social Practices and Disciplinary Interactions

Because writers can only guide readers to a particular interpretation rather than demonstrate proof, readers always have the option of refuting the writers' interpretations. At the heart of academic persuasion, then, is writers' attempts to anticipate possible negative reactions to their claims. To do this they must display familiarity with the persuasive practices of their disciplines, encoding ideas, employing warrants, and framing arguments in ways that their potential audience will find most convincing. They also have to convey their credibility by establishing a professionally acceptable persona and an appropriate attitude, both to their readers and their arguments. In sum, persuasion in academic articles, as in other areas of professional life, involves the use of language to relate independent beliefs to shared experience. Writers galvanise support, express collegiality, resolve difficulties, and negotiate disagreement through patterns of rhetorical choices which connect their texts with their disciplinary cultures.

Persuasion, then, is accomplished with language. But it is language that demonstrates legitimacy. Writers must recognize and make choices from the rhetorical options available in their fields to appeal to readers from within the boundaries of their disciplines. This involves writers making evaluations about their audience and their own relationship to this audience: how they want to present their readers and themselves in relation to their topics. In other words, academics do not just produce texts that plausibly represent an external reality. They are not just talking about garlic proteins, stress fractures or brains in vats. Instead, they use language to acknowledge, construct and negotiate social relations.

In sum, claims for the significance and originality of research have to be balanced against the convictions and expectations of readers, taking into account their likely objections, background knowledge, rhetorical expectations and processing needs.

Question for Comprehension

What is the issue of scientific writing that Hyland raises? And how can this issue be addressed?

Adapted from:

Hyland, K. (2008). Persuasion, interaction and the construction of knowledge: Representing self and others in research writing. *International Journal of English Studies, 8*(2), 1-23. https://revistas.um.es/ijes/article/view/49151

Part 2

Mark these writing characteristics as

- **H** (helpful for positioning yourself positively in the academic community) or
- **U** (unhelpful for positioning yourself positively in the academic community).

In some cases, there is room for disagreement.

No.	Writing Characteristics	H/U
1	Choosing any writing style that you like	
2	Expressing enthusiasm and commitment	
3	Writing in a formal academic style	
4	Making broad generalizations throughout a text	
5	Being cautious about generalizations	
6	Using references to support your points	
7	Writing mainly from experience and personal knowledge	
8	Reevaluating the work of authorities in the field	
9	Showing an awareness of the “hot”/controversial issues in your field	

Adapted from:

Swales, J. M., & Feak, C. B. (2012). *Academic writing for graduate students: Essential tasks and skills (3rd ed.)*. University of Michigan Press.

Part 3

Positioning through Referencing

The case of Lina Ru allows us a glimpse of a student who would by all accounts be defined as having a "writing problem" and as being in deficit. She found it difficult to articulate her research argument in writing. The focus, however, seemingly lies in language difficulties which are then identified as "writing problems." What the case highlights is that the research-writing course pedagogy enabled Lina to "see" and negotiate invisible discourse practices while at the same time allowing her to develop a voice of her own choosing and retaining some power for herself in the process. The pedagogy influenced Lina as an academic writer in three ways. First, the course encouraged participants to become discourse analysts (Bruce 2008). By emphasising the process-based character of academic contexts as social practices that change over time, by exposing the fluid nature of disciplinary discourses and by deconstructing the constructed nature of research and knowledge, participants were able to begin 'seeing' the hidden practices of the discourse. Through critical pedagogy, questioning and dialogue, students began to analyse their own position, their audience, what they wanted to achieve and how much choice they had in that goal. For Lina, in a multi-disciplinary programme, the discourse requirements were diverse, overwhelmingly untranslatable and often contradictory. It was only as she started to analyse the discourse and her professors' needs that she was able to write and produce what they required.

Second, the research-writing course emphasised developing an authorial voice. As Bruce (2008) suggested, writing well in academic contexts requires an understanding of positioning and a performance of an identity as a scholar. Again, rather than focusing on language or writing techniques, our pedagogy stressed research conceptualisation as a way of developing confidence and authority in writing. We asked students to look deeply at their research projects, from every possible angle and from multiple perspectives. We asked them to concept-map, sketch and free-write on their research many times. Through group work and peer discussions, students questioned their assumptions, arguments and standpoints, and they interrogated their epistemologies, methodologies and data collection methods. We encouraged an expansive approach that led to choices that ultimately ended with final conceptualisations. Since we were not 'content' experts, we only facilitated the process and the participants did the work together as a collaborative effort. Ultimately, as Lina shows, the shifting and sorting of decisions allowed the students to develop a deep confidence about their research and what they wanted to achieve which became part of their writing style.

Third, the authorial voice was developed not at the cost of their own personal desires and voices but as a process of critical competence (Bruce, 2008) that allowed students the choice to challenge prevailing practices, discourses and systems with an understanding of the possible consequences and outcomes. Again, Lina illustrates how she was able to convince her examiners of the value of a 'non-traditional' topic (love) and format (photography and poetry) that fulfilled her own goals and also satisfied the knowledge requirements of the degree. She was able to make that choice, an empowered choice, and not feel compelled to conduct research and write in a particular way. While, not all students who attended the course became adept discourse analysts, or nurtured strong authorial voices or developed critical competence in the way that Lina did, most found what they learned was enabling and empowering. The key concept around which everything else pivoted was choice. The ability to make choices with understanding of discursive practices led to empowered writers.

Adapted from:

Badenhorst, C., Moloney, C., Rosales, J., Dyer, J., & Ru, L. (2015). Beyond deficit: Graduate student research-writing pedagogies. *Teaching in Higher Education*, *20*(1), 1-11.